

Chapter 1

Theoretical Background

1.1 Optical Dipole Trap

Optical traps are experimental tools that allow the confinement of atom or ions within a localized region of space, under the condition that these particles have a kinetic energy lower than the trap potential depth (typically below 1mK). For the work presented in this thesis, among all possible trapping techniques, the focus will be strictly placed on Optical Dipole Traps (ODTs) for neutral atoms

Optical dipole traps rely on the electric dipole interaction of the atoms with far-detuned light. Following the work of Grimm et al. [1], this section reviews the theory behind the working mechanism of this technique, particularly in the case of red-detuned ODTs.

1.1.1 Oscillator model

The optical dipole force arises from the interaction of the induced atomic momentum with the intensity gradient of the light field. It is a conservative force, thus in the following its potential energy will be derived modelling the atom as an oscillator subjected to a classical oscillating electric field.

1.1.1.1 Interaction between induced dipole moment and driving field

The laser field is modeled as the oscillating electric field:

$$\mathbf{E}(\mathbf{r}, t) = \hat{\mathbf{e}}\mathcal{E}(r)e^{-i\omega t} + c.c. , \quad (1.1)$$

where $\hat{\mathbf{e}}$ is the unitary polarization vector and $\mathcal{E}(r)$ is the complex amplitude of the field. Denoting the atomic polarizability as α , the induced dipole momentum of the atom is given by:

$$\mathbf{p}(\mathbf{r}, t) = \alpha\mathbf{E}(\mathbf{r}, t) = \hat{\mathbf{e}}\alpha\mathcal{E}e^{-i\omega t} + c.c. \quad (1.2)$$

In the semiclassical framework, the interaction of a neutral atom with a laser light field can be described using the dipole approximation. The interaction Hamiltonian takes the form $H_{\text{dip}} = -\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{E}$. For an induced dipole, where the dipole moment depends linearly on the external field, the potential energy is obtained by integrating the interaction over the charging of the dipole:

$$U_{\text{dip}}(t) = \int_0^{\mathbf{E}} -\alpha \mathbf{E}' \cdot d\mathbf{E}' = -\frac{1}{2}\alpha E^2 = -\frac{1}{2}\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{E}. \quad (1.3)$$

Averaging over a field period [1]:

$$U_{\text{dip}} = -2\langle \mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{E} \rangle = -\frac{1}{2\epsilon_0 c} \text{Re}[\alpha] I, \quad (1.4)$$

where $I = 1/2\epsilon_0 c |\mathcal{E}|^2$ is the time-averaged field intensity.

This result shows that an atom in an oscillating laser field experiences a force proportional to the field intensity I , and to the real part of the polarizability which represent the in-phase component of the dipole oscillation, responsible for the dispersive properties of the interaction.

It follows that the dipole force is a conservative force proportional to the electric field intensity gradient:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{dip}}(\mathbf{r}) = -\nabla U_{\text{dip}} = \frac{1}{2\epsilon_0 c} \text{Re}[\alpha] \nabla I(\mathbf{r}). \quad (1.5)$$

The dipole oscillation absorbs a power

$$P_{\text{abs}} = \langle \dot{\mathbf{p}} \mathbf{E} \rangle = 2\omega \text{Im}[\alpha \mathcal{E}^2] = \frac{\omega}{2\epsilon_0 c} \text{Im}[\alpha] I, \quad (1.6)$$

which is proportional to the out-of-phase component of the oscillating dipole. The absorbed power can be seen as series of absorption and spontaneous emission of photons with energy $\hbar\omega$. Therefore, the total scattering rate is given by

$$\Gamma_{\text{sc}}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{P_{\text{abs}}}{\hbar\omega} = \frac{1}{\hbar\epsilon_0 c} \text{Im}[\alpha] I(\mathbf{r}). \quad (1.7)$$

1.1.1.2 Atomic polarizability

The polarizability α can be calculated by considering the classical Lorentz oscillator model for the atom, according to which the polarizability can be calculated by solving the differential equation

$$\ddot{x} + \Gamma(\omega)\dot{x} + \omega_0^2 x = -\frac{eE(t)}{m_e}, \quad (1.8)$$

Using $E(t) = \mathcal{E}_0 \exp(-i\omega t)$, thus looking for a solution in the form $x(t) = x_0 \exp(-i\omega t)$, equation (1.8) gives

$$x_0 = -\frac{e\mathcal{E}_0}{m_e} \frac{1}{\omega_0^2 - \omega^2 - i\omega\Gamma(\omega)}. \quad (1.9)$$

Using $p = -ex(t) = -ex_0 \exp(-i\omega t)$ and (1.9), one can easily obtain the polarizability

$$\alpha(\omega) = \frac{e^2}{m_e} \frac{1}{\omega_0^2 - \omega^2 - i\omega\Gamma(\omega)}, \quad (1.10)$$

where $\Gamma(\omega)$ is the classical damping rate due to the radiative energy loss.

$$\Gamma^{\text{class.}}(\omega) = \frac{e^2\omega^2}{6\pi\epsilon_0 m_e c^3}. \quad (1.11)$$

Defining the on-resonance spontaneous emission rate $\Gamma \equiv \Gamma^{\text{class.}}(\omega_0) = (\omega_0/\omega)^2 \Gamma^{\text{class.}}(\omega)$, the polarizability becomes

$$\alpha(\omega) = 6\pi\epsilon_0 c^3 \frac{\Gamma/\omega_0^2}{\omega_0^2 - \omega^2 - i(\omega^3/\omega_0^2)\Gamma}. \quad (1.12)$$

In a quantum two level system subjected to classical radiation, Γ should be substituted with the spontaneous emission rate

$$\Gamma = \frac{\omega_0^3}{3\pi\epsilon_0 \hbar c^3} |\langle e | \hat{d} | g \rangle|^2, \quad (1.13)$$

where $\hat{d}$ is the dipole moment operator.

Optical dipole traps works in the regime of far-detuned low intensity light, thus there is no need to calculate the quantum result, and use the classical result instead [1].

1.1.1.3 Dipole potential and scattering rate

Substituting α form (1.12) in (1.4) and (1.7) one gets the expressions of the dipole potential and the scattering rate of a dipole trap as explicit function of ω , ω_0 and Γ :

$$U_{\text{dip}}(\mathbf{r}) = -\frac{3\pi c^2}{2\omega_0^3} \left(\frac{\Gamma}{\omega_0 - \omega} + \frac{\Gamma}{\omega_0 + \omega} \right) I(\mathbf{r}), \quad (1.14)$$

$$\Gamma_{\text{sc}}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{3\pi c^2}{2\hbar\omega_0^3} \left(\frac{\omega}{\omega_0} \right)^3 \left(\frac{\Gamma}{\omega_0 - \omega} + \frac{\Gamma}{\omega_0 + \omega} \right)^2 I(\mathbf{r}). \quad (1.15)$$

These equations show two resonance frequency for $\omega = \pm\omega_0$. Introducing the detuning $\Delta = \omega - \omega_0$, for the far-red regime it holds that $\Gamma \ll |\Delta|$. For instance, the D_2 line in Rb atoms has a transition frequency of ≈ 3.8 THz thus a trap works generally at few THz of detuning, while $\Gamma \approx 36$ MHz. This allows the introduction of the well-known rotating-

wave approximation, according to which the anti-resonant term can be neglected, further simplifying the equations to

$$U_{\text{dip}}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{3\pi c^2}{2\omega_0^3} \frac{\Gamma}{\Delta} I(\mathbf{r}) \quad (1.16)$$

$$\Gamma_{\text{sc}}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{3\pi c^2}{2\hbar\omega_0^3} \left(\frac{\Gamma}{\Delta} \right)^2 I(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{\Gamma}{\hbar\Delta} U_{\text{dip}} \quad (1.17)$$

Equations (1.16) and (1.17) are the fundamental equations governing the behavior of optical dipole traps and yield important physical considerations for their implementation. The sign of U_{dip} is determined by the sign of the detuning Δ . For red detuning ($\Delta < 0$) the potential is negative, confining atoms at intensity maxima, whereas for blue detuning ($\Delta > 0$), the potential is positive pushing atoms to intensity minima. Because the potential depth scales as I/δ while the scattering rate scales as I/Δ^2 , optical traps are typically realized with high intensity field and large detunings, in this way, the trap depth is maximized while maintaining a low scattering rate.

1.1.2 Multi-level atoms

Moving from the two-level atom to a real atom, the electronic transitions become more complex, and the calculation of the dipole potential must take into consideration all the possible allowed transition. This lead to a dipole potential that depends on the particular sub-state of the atom.

1.1.2.1 Ground-state light shifts

Labelling as ε_i the energy levels of the multi-level atom, the effect of the laser light on the levels can be described by means of the non-degenerate time-independent second order perturbation theory. Considering the interaction Hamiltonian $\mathcal{H}_I = -\hat{\mathbf{d}}\mathbf{E}$, the perturbative correction on the i -th energy level is

$$\Delta E_i = \sum_{j \neq i} \frac{|\langle j | \mathcal{H}_I | i \rangle|^2}{\varepsilon_i - \varepsilon_j}. \quad (1.18)$$

The calculation can be developed by employing the dressed atom approach, in which the quantum states describe the combined atom-field system. Defining the unperturbed atomic ground state energy as zero, in this framework an unperturbed dressed state has an energy $\varepsilon_i = n\hbar\omega$ that depends solely on the number of photons n in the field. The absorption of a photon transitions the system to another dressed state characterized by the energy $\varepsilon_j = \hbar\omega_j + \hbar(n-1)\hbar\omega$, where $\hbar\omega_j$ represent the bare atomic transition energy.

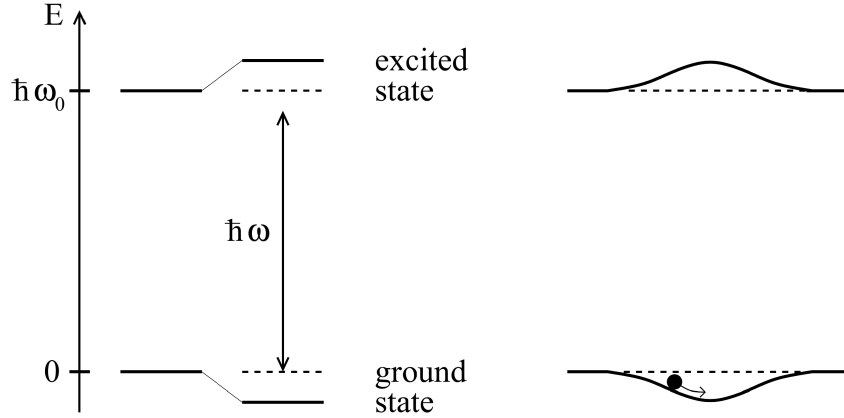


Figure 1.1: From [1]. Left: light-shifted energy levels for a two-level atom for a red detuning ($\Delta < 0$). Right: a spatially inhomogeneous field produces a potential well that traps the atoms.

In such a way, the denominator of equation (1.18) reduces to

$$\varepsilon_i - \varepsilon_j = -\hbar\omega_j + \hbar\omega = -\hbar\Delta_{ij}, \quad (1.19)$$

where Δ_{ij} is the detuning of the transition with respect to the laser field.

Considering a two-level atom first, (1.18) has only one term, using equations (1.13) and (1.19) and $I = 2\epsilon_0 c |\mathcal{E}|^2$, one gets:

$$\Delta E = \pm \frac{|\langle e|\mu|g\rangle|^2}{\Delta} |E|^2 = \pm \frac{3\pi c^2}{2\omega_0^3} \frac{\Gamma}{\Delta} I, \quad (1.20)$$

for the ground and excited state (upper and lower sign, respectively). Equation (1.20) shows that the energy shift of the ground state (the solution with the sign +) exactly correspond to the dipole potential (1.16). This allows the reinterpretation of the semi-classical result obtain for the external degrees of freedom (position and momentum) in terms of the dynamic of the internal degrees of freedom. In presence of the laser field, the energy levels are shifted by a quantity proportional to the field intensity with a sign that depends on the sign of the detuning. If a low saturation regime is assumed ($I/\Delta \ll 1$), all the atom can be considered in the ground state, and the light-shifted ground state became the effective potential that govern the motion of the atoms which drives them toward region of minima of ΔE (Figure 1.1).

For a multi-level atom equation (1.18) contains many terms similar to equation (1.20), accounting for all the allowed transitions from any ground state sublevel $|g_i\rangle$ to any excited state $|e_j\rangle$. However, each of these terms depends on the dipole matrix element $d_{ij} = \langle g_i|\hat{d}|e_j\rangle$. Such quantity can be expressed as

$$d_{ij} = c_{ij} |d| \quad (1.21)$$

where $||d||$ is the reduced matrix element given by (1.13) and c_{ij} are real transition coefficients that take into account the coupling strength of the two involved states $|g_i\rangle$ and $|e_j\rangle$, and depends on their angular momentum value [1][2].

Therefore, the energy shift (1.18) for the ground state $|g_i\rangle$ is

$$\Delta E_i = \frac{3\pi c^2 \Gamma}{2\omega_0^3} I \times \sum_j \frac{c_{ij}^2}{\Delta_{ij}} \quad (1.22)$$

and according to the interpretation given from the two-level atoms, the dipole potential at low saturation is

$$U_{\text{dip}} = \Delta E_i. \quad (1.23)$$

Thus, the dipole potential in a multi-level atom arises from the contribution of all the allowed transition, each weighted by the ratio between its line strengths c_{ij}^2 and its detuning Δ_{ij} .

1.1.2.2 Fine and Hyperfine structures contribution for Alkali atoms

Many laser cooling experiments utilize alkali metal atoms. This preference arises because their principal transition frequencies fall within the VIS-IR range making them easily accessible with standard laser technologies. Moreover, their relatively simple atomic structure are particularly convenient, allowing easy identification of closed transitions necessary for continuous cooling cycles, while minimizing the number of repumper lasers needed to address the population leaking to dark states.

When considering the fine structure arising from the spin-orbit interaction, the electronic ground state of alkali atoms is $^2S_{1/2}$. From this state, the electric dipole selection rules ($\Delta L = \pm 1$, $\Delta S = 0$) allow for two primary transitions, known as *D*-lines:

- $D_1: ^2S_{1/2} \rightarrow ^2P_{1/2};$
- $D_2: ^2S_{1/2} \rightarrow ^2P_{3/2}.$

Beyond the fine structure, the energy levels undergo further splitting due to the coupling between the nuclear spin and the total electronic angular momentum. The resulting configuration is called hyperfine structure. Denoting the fine structure splitting as $\hbar\Delta_{FS}$, the ground state hyperfine splitting as $\hbar\Delta_{HFS}$, and the excited state hyperfine splitting as $\hbar\Delta'_{HFS}$, these characteristic energy scales obey $\Delta_{FS} \gg \Delta_{HFS} \gg \Delta'_{HFS}$. The complete electronic energy level scheme for an alkali atom with nuclear spin $I = 3/2$ is shown in figure 1.2.

Assuming that all optical detunings stay large compared with the excited-state hyperfine splitting Δ'_{HFS} , equation (1.22) can be calculated for an alkali atom in the ground state

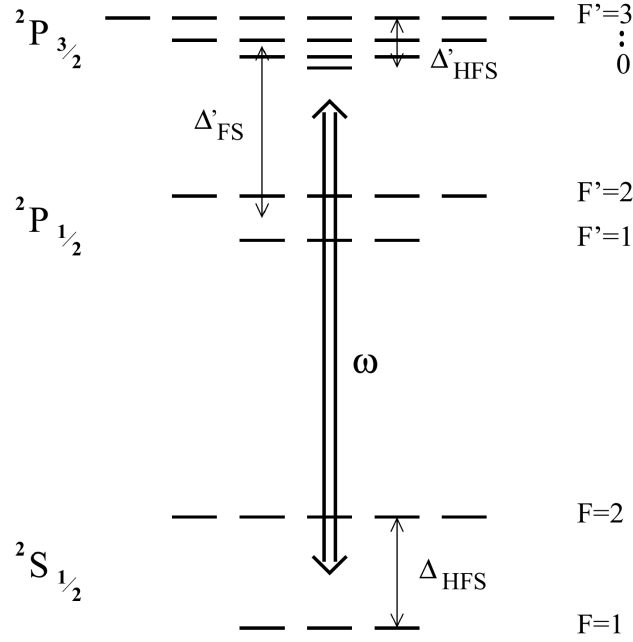


Figure 1.2: From [1]. Energy level scheme of an alkali atom with $I = 3/2$ such as ^{87}Rb .

of total angular momentum F and magnetic quantum number m_F , obtaining [1]:

$$U_{\text{dip}}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{\pi c^2 \Gamma}{2\omega_0^3} \left(\frac{2 + \mathcal{P}g_F m_F}{\Delta_{2,F}} + \frac{1 - \mathcal{P}g_F m_F}{\Delta_{1,F}} \right) I(\mathbf{r}), \quad (1.24)$$

where the two term in the parentheses represent respectively the contribution of the D_2 and D_1 line. Here, g_F is the Landé factor, $\mathcal{P}$ characterizes the laser polarization ($\mathcal{P} = 0, \pm 1$ for linear polarization and circular $\sigma^\pm$ respectively), and $\Delta_{2,F}$ and $\Delta_{1,F}$ denote the detunings of the laser field relative to the transitions from the $^2S_{1/2}, F$ ground state to the center of respectively the $^2P_{3/2}$ and $^2P_{1/2}$ hyperfine excited state.

If the detunings are large with respect to the fine-structure splitting ($|\Delta_{1,F}|, |\Delta_{2,F}| \gg \Delta'_{FS}$), introducing the detuning Δ with respect to the center of the D -line doublet, expanding equation (1.24) at first order of the small parameter Δ'_{FS}/Δ , one gets [1]:

$$U_{\text{dip}}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{3\pi c^2}{2\omega_0^3} \frac{\Gamma}{\Delta} \left(1 + \frac{1}{3} \mathcal{P}g_F m_F \frac{\Delta'_{FS}}{\Delta} \right) I(\mathbf{r}). \quad (1.25)$$

The zeroth order term corresponds exactly to the dipole potential of a simple two-level atom (see Eq. (1.16)). The first-order term introduces a small, spin-dependent correction depending on the laser polarization $\mathcal{P}$ and the magnetic quantum number m_F .

Physically, equation (1.25) describes that, when the fine structure is completely unresolved due to the large laser detuning, the atom effectively acts as a generic two-level system undergoing an $s \rightarrow p$ transition. Consequently, the resulting dipole potential is dominated by the scalar term, matching the two-level model previously discussed.

Since in the unresolved fine structure case, the polarization-dependent term is heavily suppressed by the small parameter Δ'_{FS}/Δ (and vanishes entirely for linearly polarized light), the atom effectively acquires only the scalar light shift of the unperturbed s state. Consequently, all hyperfine and magnetic sublevels experience a uniform trapping potential that confines the gas while preserving its internal spin degeneracy.

In a more general case, when the fine structure is resolved, but the hyperfine structure is unresolved ($|\Delta_{1,F}|, |\Delta_{2,F}| \gg \Delta_{HFS} \gg \Delta'_{HFS}$), only linearly polarized light guarantees that the dipole potential becomes completely independent of m_F and F [1]. Therefore, linearly polarized light is usually employed for dipole trap implementation.

1.1.3 Heating mechanism

Typical trap depths for optical dipole traps are usually below 1 mK. Therefore, capturing a substantial number of atoms requires a preliminary cooling stage. For instance, the experiment discussed in this thesis employs a magneto-optical trap (MOT) followed by an optical molasses phase.

Given these shallow confining potentials, even minor heating rates can largely limit the trap lifetime. It is therefore important to outline the mechanisms responsible for the parasitic heating induced by the trapping light.

1.1.4 Heating source

When atoms interact with laser light the fluctuations in the spontaneous emission and absorption, always causes a heating process, this is the phenomenon that puts a lower limit to cooling mechanism [3][2]. For the optical dipole trap the atoms absorb photons and re-emits them in random direction (isotropic radiation), statistical oscillations in both these two processes cause heating. The absorption of photons from the dipole light causes a recoil energy of $E_{\text{rec}} = k_B T_{\text{rec}}/2$ per scattering event and happens only in the direction of the laser beam and is therefore anisotropic. On the other hand, also the re-emission scattering events cause a recoil energy E_{rec} , however the direction of emission is random, thus the effect is spread over all the three spatial direction. Thus, for a single cycle the atom receives E_{rec} from the absorption and then E_{rec} from the spontaneous emission, for a total of E_{rec} , in a time $\bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}}^{-1}$.

It leads to the total heating power:

$$P_{\text{heat}} = 2E_{\text{rec}}\bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}} = k_B T_{\text{rec}}\bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}} \quad (1.26)$$

thus the heating depends on the mean scattering rate $\bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}}$ and on the recoil E_{rec} which depends on the laser frequency.

Other fundamental source of heating, such as the redistribution of photons between different travelling wave, should be quenched by the far-detuned working frequency [1].

1.1.5 Heating rate

Assuming that the system reaches the thermal equilibrium, the mean energy can be expressed through the energy equipartition theorem. Assuming the trap as a three-dimensional harmonic potential well, there is a contribution of three quadratic degrees of freedom from the kinetic energy and other three from the harmonic potential. According to the energy partition theorem, the mean energy is:

$$\bar{E} = 3k_B T. \quad (1.27)$$

Using equation (1.26) in equation (1.27), one can obtain an equation that describes the temperature change with time:

$$\dot{T} = \frac{1}{3} T_{\text{rec}} \bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}}. \quad (1.28)$$

Expressing the dipole potential as

$$\bar{U}_{\text{dip}} = U_0 + \bar{E}_{\text{pot}} = U_0 + \frac{3}{2} k_B T, \quad (1.29)$$

where U_0 is the potential energy minimum, then the scattering rate $\bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}}$ can be expressed by Substituting U_{dip} from (1.17), obtaining

$$\bar{\Gamma}_{\text{sc}} = \frac{\Gamma}{\hbar \Delta} (U_0 + \frac{3}{2} k_B T). \quad (1.30)$$

It is important to notice that for a blue-detuned trap, $U_0 = 0$ and the trap depth $\hat{U}$ is given by the maximum value of the potential surrounding the minimum, while for a red-detuned trap $\hat{U} = |U_0|$. Finally, using equation (1.30) in (1.28), with a depth $\hat{U} \gg k_B T$, one gets the following temperature changing rate for a red and a blue trap:

$$\dot{T}_{\text{red}} = \frac{1}{3} T_{\text{rec}} \frac{\Gamma}{\hbar |\Delta|} \hat{U}, \quad (1.31a)$$

$$\dot{T}_{\text{blue}} = \frac{1}{2} T_{\text{rec}} \frac{\Gamma}{\hbar \Delta} k_B T. \quad (1.31b)$$

Equation (1.31a) shows another limitation for the blue trap: while a red trap has a linear heating rate (as long as $\hat{U} \gg k_B T$), the blue trap shows an exponential heating law.

1.1.6 Implementation

1.2 Optical Fibers